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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: No Date Given

Coverage Date: 1910 AD - 1963 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): BLOOD COVENANT

In the past, girl novices (*wali*) were confined indoors for a year or more after their first menstruation. This seclusion (*kumbi*) was marked with a celebration (*ngoma ya tumi* or *kuvunja unga*) and later by a second feast (*ngoma mwikiro*). The terminology for all these celebrations seems to vary greatly from area to area. During their seclusion the girls are fattened and are also taught sexual lore. Sometimes figurines are used in this instruction. Girls' genitals are not cut. These instructions are concluded with rites (*mkole* or *gali-gali*) which end in a girl's emergence (*mlea*). She is shaved, anointed, given new ornaments and carried about on the shoulders of young men. In the past, a girl had often been engaged before puberty, but, in any case, she would be married very shortly after her emergence celebrations. Young people receive sexual instruction from members of alternate ascending generations.

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BURIAL (McVicar, 1945; Morogoro District Book; Kimmenade, ms; Christensen, pp. 1320–1; Scheerder and Tastevin, pp. 272–3; Mzuanda, pp. 141–4)

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Burial and mortuary rites are conducted by clan joking partners (*watani*). These sweep the floor of a hut, wash the corpse and wrap it in burial cloth (*sanda*), and announce the circumstances of the death. They are also in charge of shaving mourners, sacrificing at graves during mortuary rites, and in rekindling household fires at the end of mourning. Authorities differ on their

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Political succession is discussed under the heading of Clans and Lineages.

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RELIGION (Scheerder and Tastevin, pp. 271–9; McVicar (1935), ms; Morogoro District Book; Kimmenade, ms; Mzuanda, pp. 148–50)

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Luguru believe in a supreme being (*mulungu*), but confine most of their ritual activity to propitiation of ancestral ghosts (*wazimu*). These rites (*kutambika*) are  34 directed by the head of the matrilineage but some are conducted in part by joking partners (*watani*). The sites for such ceremonies are sacred groves where many important matrilineal ancestors are buried. The propitiants wear bracelets (*lugenge*) after such ceremonies. Ancestral ghosts are propitiated for rainmaking and during times of difficulty. The nature of such difficulties and the means of correcting them are determined through divination. Sometimes such ghosts possess living kinsmen (maternal and paternal); after being detected by divination, such ghosts are exorcised by having their names given to the humans they are possessing. Ancestral propitiation takes place in tiny huts (*kibanda cha muzimu*) built for such purposes; there is one for each matrilineal area. At the time of the first rains, the lineage leader propitiates ancestral ghosts; in some areas certain rainmakers have gained influence over much wider regions (cf. political system). Ancestral ghosts were also propitiated at harvest when the lineage head took a token of first-fruits and deposited some at crossroads and/or ate some himself. Only after this was done might others consume the new harvest. Such rites were called *kulimbua* or *kuzirula*. Medicines (*madza*, water?) were also placed on harvests stored in granaries to make these safe and pure; such rites were called *kuhoza*.

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